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50 RECIPES + 3 BAKING LESSONS

Cheesecakes, Cupcakes & Mini Cakes

A Complete Collection of Small-Format Baking for Every Occasion

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A Complete Collection of Small-Format Baking for Every Occasion

Cheesecakes, Cupcakes & Mini Cakes

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This book is sold for personal use. Recipes are provided for home baking; please check your own equipment, ingredient brands, and altitude, as results can vary. These recipes are based on standard baking and pastry ratios, not on documented testing of every recipe in this book. Baked and no-bake cheesecakes use different methods that are not interchangeable — follow the method each recipe specifies.

Always check ingredient labels for allergens before serving to guests.

Contents

PART 1	Fundamentals	4
PART 2	Baked Cheesecakes	6
PART 3	No-Bake Cheesecakes	18
PART 4	Cupcakes	28
PART 5	Mini Cakes & Individual Desserts	44
	Index	56

PART 1

Fundamentals

Three short lessons on the difference between baked and no-bake cheesecake, preventing cracks, and getting cupcakes right.

Baked vs. No-Bake Cheesecake: Not Interchangeable

A baked cheesecake sets through gentle, low heat, which gives it a dense, custard-like texture and lets it hold a tall shape without any added gelatin. A no-bake cheesecake sets purely through chilling, usually with the help of whipped cream and sometimes gelatin, giving it a lighter, mousse-like texture.

These two styles are not simply the same filling with or without an oven. Baked cheesecake batter is thinner and relies on egg proteins to set firm as it bakes; a no-bake filling is whipped to add volume and needs enough structure (from whipped cream, gelatin, or both) to hold its shape purely from chilling, often for several hours or overnight.

Using a no-bake method on a baked recipe will leave you with a filling that never sets. Baking a no-bake recipe will usually just melt it. Follow the method each recipe specifies, and don't swap bake times or oven temperatures between the two styles.

- Baked cheesecake: sets with gentle oven heat, dense and custard-like
- No-bake cheesecake: sets by chilling, lighter and mousse-like, often with whipped cream or gelatin
- The two methods are not interchangeable — follow each recipe's specified method
- No-bake cheesecakes typically need several hours or overnight to set fully

Water Baths and Preventing Cracks

A water bath surrounds the cheesecake pan with hot water in the oven, which moderates the heat so the edges don't overbake while the center is still setting. To use one, wrap the outside of a springform pan tightly in two layers of heavy-duty foil, then set it in a larger roasting pan and add hot water halfway up the sides of the cheesecake pan before baking.

Cracks usually come from overbaking or cooling too quickly. A cheesecake is done when the edges are set but the center still has a slight wobble, like gelatin — it will continue to firm up as it cools. Turn off the oven and let the cheesecake sit inside with the door propped open for about an hour before removing it, which prevents the sudden temperature change that often causes the top to crack.

Overmixing the batter, especially after adding eggs, incorporates extra air that expands in the oven and can cause the surface to crack as it later deflates. Mix just until smooth once the eggs go in.

- Wrap the pan in foil and surround with hot water for a water bath
- Done when the edges are set and the center has a slight wobble
- Cool gradually in the turned-off oven with the door propped open
- Avoid overmixing once eggs are added — extra air can cause cracking

Cupcakes: Portioning, Baking, and Frosting Height

Fill cupcake liners about two-thirds full. Overfilling causes cupcakes to dome too much and spill over the liner; underfilling gives flat, short cupcakes. A standard ice cream scoop or a 1/4-cup measure makes portioning even and quick.

Cupcakes bake faster than layer cakes, usually 16-20 minutes, and are done by the same toothpick test. Check a few minutes early the first time you make a new recipe, since muffin tins vary in how evenly they conduct heat.

For a generous frosted look without using excessive frosting, pipe in a tall swirl using a large open star or round tip rather than spreading frosting flat — height reads as more generous visually while using a similar amount of frosting as a thick, flat layer.

- Fill liners two-thirds full for an even dome
- Cupcakes usually bake 16-20 minutes — check early the first time
- A piped swirl looks more generous than a flat spread of the same amount
- Cool completely before frosting, same as layer cakes

PART 2

Baked Cheesecakes

Twelve baked cheesecakes, set in the oven with a water bath, from the classic New York style to spiced, swirled, and layered versions.

Classic New York Cheesecake

Baked, dense, and tall — the benchmark cheesecake this book's other baked versions build on.

PREP 20 MIN • BAKE 60-70 MIN • CHILL 6 HOURS OR OVERNIGHT • 9-INCH SPRINGFORM PAN • 325F/160C • 12 SLICES

CRUST

- 1 1/2 cups (150g) graham cracker crumbs
- 5 tbsp (70g) unsalted butter, melted
- 2 tbsp granulated sugar

FILLING

- 32 oz (900g) cream cheese, softened
- 1 1/4 cups (250g) granulated sugar
- 4 large eggs, room temperature
- 1/3 cup (75g) sour cream
- 1 tbsp vanilla extract
- 2 tbsp all-purpose flour

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 325F/160C. Mix the crust ingredients and press firmly into the bottom of the springform pan. Bake 10 minutes, then cool slightly.
2. Wrap the outside of the pan in two layers of heavy-duty foil for a water bath.
3. Beat the cream cheese and sugar until smooth, about 2 minutes, scraping the bowl well.
4. Add the eggs one at a time, mixing on low just until combined. Mix in the sour cream, vanilla, and flour.
5. Pour over the crust, set the pan in a larger roasting pan, and add hot water halfway up the sides.
6. Bake 60-70 minutes, until the edges are set and the center has a slight wobble.

7. Turn off the oven, prop the door open, and let the cheesecake cool inside for 1 hour, then refrigerate at least 6 hours or overnight before releasing the springform ring.

Storage: Refrigerate up to 5 days.

Allergens: Contains wheat, egg, and dairy.

Baked Vanilla Bean Cheesecake

A lighter, less tangy baked cheesecake, built around real vanilla bean.

PREP 20 MIN • BAKE 55-65 MIN • CHILL 6 HOURS OR OVERNIGHT • 9-INCH SPRINGFORM PAN • 325F/160C • 12 SLICES

CRUST

- 1 1/2 cups (150g) vanilla wafer crumbs
- 5 tbsp (70g) unsalted butter, melted

FILLING

- 24 oz (680g) cream cheese, softened
- 1 cup (200g) granulated sugar
- 3 large eggs, room temperature
- 1/4 cup (60g) sour cream
- 2 tsp vanilla bean paste

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 325F/160C. Mix the crust ingredients and press into the pan. Bake 8 minutes, then cool slightly.
2. Wrap the pan in foil for a water bath.
3. Beat the cream cheese and sugar until smooth. Add the eggs one at a time, mixing just until combined.
4. Mix in the sour cream and vanilla bean paste.
5. Pour over the crust, place in a water bath, and bake 55-65 minutes, until the edges are set and the center still wobbles slightly.
6. Cool in the turned-off oven for 1 hour, then refrigerate at least 6 hours before serving.

Storage: Refrigerate up to 5 days.

Allergens: Contains wheat, egg, and dairy.

Baked Chocolate Cheesecake

Melted dark chocolate folded into the classic baked filling.

PREP 20 MIN • BAKE 55-65 MIN • CHILL 6 HOURS OR OVERNIGHT • 9-INCH SPRINGFORM PAN • 325F/160C • 12 SLICES

CRUST

- 1 1/2 cups (150g) chocolate cookie crumbs
- 5 tbsp (70g) unsalted butter, melted

FILLING

- 24 oz (680g) cream cheese, softened
- 1 cup (200g) granulated sugar
- 8 oz (226g) semisweet chocolate, melted and cooled
- 3 large eggs, room temperature
- 1/4 cup (60g) sour cream
- 1 tsp vanilla extract

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 325F/160C. Press the crumb mixture into the pan and bake 8 minutes, then cool.
2. Wrap the pan in foil for a water bath.
3. Beat the cream cheese and sugar until smooth, then beat in the melted chocolate.
4. Add the eggs one at a time, then mix in the sour cream and vanilla.
5. Pour over the crust, place in a water bath, and bake 55-65 minutes, until just set with a slight wobble.
6. Cool in the turned-off oven for 1 hour, then refrigerate at least 6 hours.

Storage: Refrigerate up to 5 days.

Allergens: Contains wheat, egg, and dairy.

Baked Lemon Cheesecake

Bright and tangy, cut with real lemon zest and juice rather than extract.

PREP 20 MIN • BAKE 55-65 MIN • CHILL 6 HOURS OR OVERNIGHT • 9-INCH SPRINGFORM PAN • 325F/160C • 12 SLICES

CRUST

- 1 1/2 cups (150g) graham cracker crumbs
- 5 tbsp (70g) unsalted butter, melted

FILLING

- 24 oz (680g) cream cheese, softened
- 1 cup (200g) granulated sugar
- 3 large eggs, room temperature
- 1/4 cup (60g) sour cream
- Zest of 2 lemons
- 3 tbsp fresh lemon juice

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 325F/160C. Press the crust into the pan and bake 8 minutes, then cool.
2. Wrap the pan in foil for a water bath.
3. Beat the cream cheese, sugar, and lemon zest until smooth.
4. Add the eggs one at a time, then mix in the sour cream and lemon juice.
5. Pour over the crust, place in a water bath, and bake 55-65 minutes, until just set with a slight wobble.
6. Cool in the turned-off oven for 1 hour, then refrigerate at least 6 hours.

Storage: Refrigerate up to 5 days.

Allergens: Contains wheat, egg, and dairy.

Baked Pumpkin Cheesecake

A spiced baked cheesecake built on real pumpkin puree, not just pumpkin spice flavoring.

PREP 20 MIN • BAKE 60-70 MIN • CHILL 6 HOURS OR OVERNIGHT • 9-INCH SPRINGFORM PAN • 325F/160C • 12 SLICES

CRUST

- 1 1/2 cups (150g) graham cracker crumbs
- 5 tbsp (70g) unsalted butter, melted
- 1/2 tsp ground cinnamon

FILLING

- 24 oz (680g) cream cheese, softened
- 1 cup (200g) packed brown sugar
- 1 cup (240g) pumpkin puree
- 3 large eggs, room temperature
- 1 1/2 tsp ground cinnamon
- 1/2 tsp ground ginger
- 1/4 tsp ground cloves

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 325F/160C. Press the crust into the pan and bake 8 minutes, then cool.
2. Wrap the pan in foil for a water bath.
3. Beat the cream cheese and brown sugar until smooth, then beat in the pumpkin puree.
4. Add the eggs one at a time, then mix in the spices.
5. Pour over the crust, place in a water bath, and bake 60-70 minutes, until just set with a slight wobble.
6. Cool in the turned-off oven for 1 hour, then refrigerate at least 6 hours.

Storage: Refrigerate up to 5 days.

Allergens: Contains wheat, egg, and dairy.

Baked Cherry Swirl Cheesecake

A plain baked filling swirled with a quick cherry sauce before baking.

PREP 25 MIN • BAKE 55-65 MIN • CHILL 6 HOURS OR OVERNIGHT • 9-INCH SPRINGFORM PAN • 325F/160C • 12 SLICES

CRUST

- 1 1/2 cups (150g) graham cracker crumbs
- 5 tbsp (70g) unsalted butter, melted

FILLING

- 24 oz (680g) cream cheese, softened
- 1 cup (200g) granulated sugar
- 3 large eggs, room temperature
- 1/4 cup (60g) sour cream
- 1 tsp vanilla extract

CHERRY SWIRL

- 1 1/2 cups (225g) pitted cherries, fresh or frozen
- 3 tbsp granulated sugar
- 1 tsp cornstarch mixed with 1 tsp water

METHOD

1. For the swirl, cook the cherries and sugar over medium heat until softened, about 5 minutes, then stir in the cornstarch slurry and simmer until thickened. Cool slightly and puree or mash.
2. Heat the oven to 325F/160C. Press the crust into the pan and bake 8 minutes, then cool.
3. Beat the cream cheese and sugar until smooth, add the eggs one at a time, then mix in the sour cream and vanilla.
4. Pour the filling over the crust, then drop spoonfuls of cherry sauce over the top and swirl gently with a knife.
5. Place in a water bath and bake 55-65 minutes, until just set with a slight wobble.
6. Cool in the turned-off oven for 1 hour, then refrigerate at least 6 hours.

Storage: Refrigerate up to 5 days.

Allergens: Contains wheat, egg, and dairy.

Mini Baked Cheesecakes

An individual-portion version of the classic baked cheesecake, no water bath needed.

PREP 15 MIN • BAKE 18-20 MIN • CHILL 3 HOURS • 12-CUP MUFFIN TIN WITH LINERS • 325F/160C • 12 MINI CHEESECAKES

CRUST

- 12 vanilla wafer cookies (one per liner)

FILLING

- 16 oz (450g) cream cheese, softened
- 2/3 cup (135g) granulated sugar
- 2 large eggs, room temperature
- 1 tsp vanilla extract

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 325F/160C. Line a muffin tin with paper liners and place one wafer cookie flat in the bottom of each.
2. Beat the cream cheese and sugar until smooth, add the eggs one at a time, then the vanilla.
3. Divide the filling evenly among the liners, filling almost to the top.
4. Bake 18-20 minutes, until just set with a slight jiggle in the center.
5. Cool to room temperature, then refrigerate at least 3 hours before serving.

Storage: Refrigerate up to 5 days.

Allergens: Contains wheat, egg, and dairy.

Baked Salted Caramel Cheesecake

A baked filling swirled with salted caramel sauce, finished with more sauce after chilling.

PREP 25 MIN • BAKE 60-70 MIN • CHILL 6 HOURS OR OVERNIGHT • 9-INCH SPRINGFORM PAN • 325F/160C • 12 SLICES

CRUST

- 1 1/2 cups (150g) graham cracker crumbs
- 5 tbsp (70g) unsalted butter, melted

FILLING

- 24 oz (680g) cream cheese, softened
- 1 cup (200g) granulated sugar
- 3 large eggs, room temperature
- 1/4 cup (60g) sour cream
- 1 tsp vanilla extract

SALTED CARAMEL

- 1/2 cup (100g) granulated sugar
- 3 tbsp (45g) unsalted butter
- 1/4 cup (60ml) heavy cream, warmed
- 1/2 tsp fine sea salt

METHOD

1. For the caramel, melt the sugar in a saucepan over medium heat without stirring until amber, then whisk in the butter, followed by the warm cream and salt. Cool slightly.
2. Heat the oven to 325F/160C. Press the crust into the pan and bake 8 minutes, then cool.
3. Beat the cream cheese and sugar until smooth, add the eggs one at a time, then the sour cream and vanilla.
4. Pour half the filling over the crust, drizzle with a third of the caramel and swirl, then repeat with the remaining filling and more caramel.
5. Place in a water bath and bake 60-70 minutes, until just set with a slight wobble.
6. Cool in the turned-off oven for 1 hour, then refrigerate at least 6 hours. Drizzle with remaining caramel before serving.

Storage: Refrigerate up to 5 days.

Allergens: Contains wheat, egg, and dairy.

Baked Oreo Cheesecake

Crushed sandwich cookies folded into a baked filling, over a cookie-crumb crust.

PREP 20 MIN • BAKE 60-70 MIN • CHILL 6 HOURS OR OVERNIGHT • 9-INCH SPRINGFORM PAN • 325F/160C • 12 SLICES

CRUST

- 24 chocolate sandwich cookies, crushed (crumbs only)
- 4 tbsp (55g) unsalted butter, melted

FILLING

- 24 oz (680g) cream cheese, softened
- 1 cup (200g) granulated sugar
- 3 large eggs, room temperature
- 1/4 cup (60g) sour cream
- 14 chocolate sandwich cookies, roughly chopped

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 325F/160C. Mix the cookie crumbs with melted butter and press into the pan. Bake 8 minutes, then cool.
2. Beat the cream cheese and sugar until smooth, add the eggs one at a time, then the sour cream.
3. Fold in the chopped cookies, then pour over the crust.
4. Place in a water bath and bake 60-70 minutes, until just set with a slight wobble.
5. Cool in the turned-off oven for 1 hour, then refrigerate at least 6 hours.

Storage: Refrigerate up to 5 days.

Allergens: Contains wheat, egg, and dairy.

Baked Raspberry Swirl Cheesecake

The same cherry-swirl technique applied to fresh or frozen raspberries, for a tarter result.

PREP 25 MIN • BAKE 55-65 MIN • CHILL 6 HOURS OR OVERNIGHT • 9-INCH SPRINGFORM PAN • 325F/160C • 12 SLICES

CRUST

- 1 1/2 cups (150g) graham cracker crumbs
- 5 tbsp (70g) unsalted butter, melted

FILLING

- 24 oz (680g) cream cheese, softened
- 1 cup (200g) granulated sugar
- 3 large eggs, room temperature
- 1/4 cup (60g) sour cream
- 1 tsp vanilla extract

RASPBERRY SWIRL

- 1 1/2 cups (190g) raspberries, fresh or frozen
- 3 tbsp granulated sugar
- 1 tsp cornstarch mixed with 1 tsp water

METHOD

1. For the swirl, cook the raspberries and sugar over medium heat until softened, about 5 minutes, then stir in the cornstarch slurry and simmer until thickened. Strain out seeds if desired, then cool.
2. Heat the oven to 325F/160C. Press the crust into the pan and bake 8 minutes, then cool.
3. Beat the cream cheese and sugar until smooth, add the eggs one at a time, then the sour cream and vanilla.
4. Pour the filling over the crust, drop spoonfuls of raspberry sauce on top, and swirl gently with a knife.
5. Place in a water bath and bake 55-65 minutes, until just set with a slight wobble.
6. Cool in the turned-off oven for 1 hour, then refrigerate at least 6 hours.

Storage: Refrigerate up to 5 days.

Allergens: Contains wheat, egg, and dairy.

Baked Tiramisu Cheesecake

Coffee and mascarpone folded into a baked filling, over a ladyfinger crust, dusted with cocoa.

PREP 25 MIN • BAKE 60-70 MIN • CHILL 6 HOURS OR OVERNIGHT • 9-INCH SPRINGFORM PAN • 325F/160C • 12 SLICES

CRUST

- 7 oz (200g) ladyfinger cookies, crushed
- 4 tbsp (55g) unsalted butter, melted

FILLING

- 16 oz (450g) cream cheese, softened
- 8 oz (225g) mascarpone, softened
- 1 cup (200g) granulated sugar
- 3 large eggs, room temperature
- 2 tbsp espresso powder dissolved in 1 tbsp hot water
- 2 tbsp cocoa powder, for dusting

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 325F/160C. Press the crushed ladyfingers and butter into the pan. Bake 8 minutes, then cool.
2. Beat the cream cheese, mascarpone, and sugar until smooth, add the eggs one at a time, then the dissolved espresso.
3. Pour over the crust, place in a water bath, and bake 60-70 minutes, until just set with a slight wobble.
4. Cool in the turned-off oven for 1 hour, then refrigerate at least 6 hours.
5. Dust the top with cocoa powder through a fine sieve just before serving.

Storage: Refrigerate up to 5 days.

Allergens: Contains wheat, egg, and dairy.

Baked Apple Cinnamon Cheesecake

A spiced baked cheesecake topped with a sauteed cinnamon-apple layer and streusel.

PREP 30 MIN • BAKE 65-75 MIN • CHILL 6 HOURS OR OVERNIGHT • 9-INCH SPRINGFORM PAN • 325F/160C • 12 SLICES

CRUST

- 1 1/2 cups (150g) graham cracker crumbs
- 5 tbsp (70g) unsalted butter, melted

FILLING

- 24 oz (680g) cream cheese, softened
- 1 cup (200g) granulated sugar
- 3 large eggs, room temperature
- 1/4 cup (60g) sour cream
- 1 tsp ground cinnamon

APPLE TOPPING & STREUSEL

- 2 apples, peeled and diced
- 2 tbsp unsalted butter
- 3 tbsp brown sugar
- 1/2 tsp ground cinnamon
- 1/3 cup (40g) all-purpose flour, 3 tbsp cold butter, 3 tbsp brown sugar (streusel)

METHOD

1. Saute the diced apples in butter, brown sugar, and cinnamon until just tender, about 5 minutes. Cool. Rub the streusel ingredients together until crumbly.
2. Heat the oven to 325F/160C. Press the crust into the pan and bake 8 minutes, then cool.
3. Beat the cream cheese and sugar until smooth, add the eggs one at a time, then the sour cream and cinnamon.
4. Pour over the crust, scatter the cooked apples and streusel over the top.
5. Place in a water bath and bake 65-75 minutes, until just set with a slight wobble.
6. Cool in the turned-off oven for 1 hour, then refrigerate at least 6 hours.

Storage: Refrigerate up to 5 days.

Allergens: Contains wheat, egg, and dairy.

PART 3

No-Bake Cheesecakes

Ten no-bake cheesecakes, set entirely by chilling — lighter in texture than their baked counterparts.

No-Bake Classic Cheesecake

Lighter than the baked version, set by whipped cream and chilling rather than an oven.

PREP 20 MIN • CHILL 6 HOURS OR OVERNIGHT • 9-INCH SPRINGFORM PAN • 12 SLICES

CRUST

- 1 1/2 cups (150g) graham cracker crumbs
- 5 tbsp (70g) unsalted butter, melted

FILLING

- 24 oz (680g) cream cheese, softened
- 1 cup (120g) powdered sugar
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- 1 1/2 cups (360ml) heavy cream, cold

METHOD

1. Press the crust mixture into the bottom of the pan and chill while you make the filling.
2. Beat the cream cheese, powdered sugar, and vanilla until smooth.
3. In a separate bowl, whip the cold heavy cream to stiff peaks.
4. Fold the whipped cream into the cream cheese mixture in two additions, gently, until no streaks remain.
5. Spread over the crust and smooth the top. Refrigerate at least 6 hours or overnight until fully set.

Storage: Refrigerate up to 4 days.

Allergens: Contains wheat and dairy.

No-Bake Strawberry Cheesecake

A fresh strawberry puree folded into the same no-bake base.

PREP 20 MIN • CHILL 6 HOURS OR OVERNIGHT • 9-INCH SPRINGFORM PAN • 12 SLICES

CRUST

- 1 1/2 cups (150g) graham cracker crumbs
- 5 tbsp (70g) unsalted butter, melted

FILLING

- 24 oz (680g) cream cheese, softened
- 1 cup (120g) powdered sugar
- 3/4 cup (180g) strawberry puree (about 1 1/2 cups fresh strawberries, blended and strained)
- 1 1/2 cups (360ml) heavy cream, cold

METHOD

1. Press the crust into the pan and chill.
2. Beat the cream cheese, powdered sugar, and strawberry puree until smooth.
3. Whip the cold cream to stiff peaks in a separate bowl, then fold into the cream cheese mixture in two additions.
4. Spread over the crust and refrigerate at least 6 hours or overnight.

Storage: Refrigerate up to 4 days.

Allergens: Contains wheat and dairy.

No-Bake Chocolate Cheesecake

Melted chocolate folded into a whipped no-bake filling for a mousse-like texture.

PREP 20 MIN • CHILL 6 HOURS OR OVERNIGHT • 9-INCH SPRINGFORM PAN • 12 SLICES

CRUST

- 1 1/2 cups (150g) chocolate cookie crumbs
- 5 tbsp (70g) unsalted butter, melted

FILLING

- 24 oz (680g) cream cheese, softened
- 3/4 cup (90g) powdered sugar
- 8 oz (226g) semisweet chocolate, melted and cooled slightly
- 1 1/2 cups (360ml) heavy cream, cold

METHOD

1. Press the crust into the pan and chill.
2. Beat the cream cheese and powdered sugar until smooth, then beat in the cooled melted chocolate.
3. Whip the cold cream to stiff peaks, then fold into the chocolate mixture in two additions.
4. Spread over the crust and refrigerate at least 6 hours or overnight.

Storage: Refrigerate up to 4 days.

Allergens: Contains wheat and dairy.

No-Bake Key Lime Cheesecake

Tart and bright, using key lime or regular lime juice and zest.

PREP 20 MIN • CHILL 6 HOURS OR OVERNIGHT • 9-INCH SPRINGFORM PAN • 12 SLICES

CRUST

- 1 1/2 cups (150g) graham cracker crumbs
- 5 tbsp (70g) unsalted butter, melted

FILLING

- 24 oz (680g) cream cheese, softened
- 1 cup (120g) powdered sugar
- Zest of 3 limes
- 1/2 cup (120ml) fresh lime juice
- 1 1/2 cups (360ml) heavy cream, cold

METHOD

1. Press the crust into the pan and chill.
2. Beat the cream cheese, powdered sugar, lime zest, and lime juice until smooth.
3. Whip the cold cream to stiff peaks, then fold into the lime mixture in two additions.
4. Spread over the crust and refrigerate at least 6 hours or overnight.

Storage: Refrigerate up to 4 days.

Allergens: Contains wheat and dairy.

No-Bake Peanut Butter Cheesecake

Rich and dense, good with a chocolate cookie crust.

PREP 20 MIN • CHILL 6 HOURS OR OVERNIGHT • 9-INCH SPRINGFORM PAN • 12 SLICES

CRUST

- 1 1/2 cups (150g) chocolate cookie crumbs
- 5 tbsp (70g) unsalted butter, melted

FILLING

- 16 oz (450g) cream cheese, softened
- 1 cup (260g) creamy peanut butter
- 1 cup (120g) powdered sugar
- 1 1/2 cups (360ml) heavy cream, cold

METHOD

1. Press the crust into the pan and chill.
2. Beat the cream cheese, peanut butter, and powdered sugar until smooth.
3. Whip the cold cream to stiff peaks, then fold into the peanut butter mixture in two additions.
4. Spread over the crust and refrigerate at least 6 hours or overnight.

Storage: Refrigerate up to 4 days.

Allergens: Contains wheat, dairy, and peanuts.

No-Bake Mini Cheesecake Cups

A no-bake filling layered into cups with crust crumbs, no springform pan needed.

PREP 20 MIN • CHILL 3 HOURS • 12 SMALL JARS OR CUPS • 12 INDIVIDUAL SERVINGS

CRUMB LAYER

- 1 1/4 cups (125g) graham cracker crumbs
- 4 tbsp (55g) unsalted butter, melted

FILLING

- 16 oz (450g) cream cheese, softened
- 3/4 cup (90g) powdered sugar
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- 1 cup (240ml) heavy cream, cold

METHOD

1. Mix the crumbs and melted butter, then divide among the bottoms of 12 small cups or jars.
2. Beat the cream cheese, powdered sugar, and vanilla until smooth.
3. Whip the cold cream to stiff peaks, then fold into the cream cheese mixture.
4. Pipe or spoon the filling over the crumb layer in each cup.
5. Refrigerate at least 3 hours before serving; top with fruit or sauce if desired just before serving.

Storage: Refrigerate up to 4 days.

Allergens: Contains wheat and dairy.

No-Bake Oreo Cheesecake

Crushed sandwich cookies folded through the base no-bake filling, over a cookie crust.

PREP 20 MIN • CHILL 6 HOURS OR OVERNIGHT • 9-INCH SPRINGFORM PAN • 12 SLICES

CRUST

- 24 chocolate sandwich cookies, crushed (crumbs only)
- 4 tbsp (55g) unsalted butter, melted

FILLING

- 24 oz (680g) cream cheese, softened
- 1 cup (120g) powdered sugar
- 1 1/2 cups (360ml) heavy cream, cold
- 12 chocolate sandwich cookies, roughly chopped

METHOD

1. Press the crust into the pan and chill.
2. Beat the cream cheese and powdered sugar until smooth.
3. Whip the cold cream to stiff peaks, fold into the cream cheese mixture, then fold in the chopped cookies.
4. Spread over the crust and refrigerate at least 6 hours or overnight.

Storage: Refrigerate up to 4 days.

Allergens: Contains wheat and dairy.

No-Bake Mango Cheesecake

A tropical no-bake filling made with real mango puree.

PREP 20 MIN • CHILL 6 HOURS OR OVERNIGHT • 9-INCH SPRINGFORM PAN • 12 SLICES

CRUST

- 1 1/2 cups (150g) graham cracker crumbs
- 5 tbsp (70g) unsalted butter, melted

FILLING

- 24 oz (680g) cream cheese, softened
- 3/4 cup (90g) powdered sugar
- 1 cup (240g) mango puree (about 2 ripe mangoes, blended)
- 1 1/2 cups (360ml) heavy cream, cold

METHOD

1. Press the crust into the pan and chill.
2. Beat the cream cheese, powdered sugar, and mango puree until smooth.
3. Whip the cold cream to stiff peaks, then fold into the mango mixture in two additions.
4. Spread over the crust and refrigerate at least 6 hours or overnight.

Storage: Refrigerate up to 4 days.

Allergens: Contains wheat and dairy.

No-Bake Nutella Cheesecake

A rich hazelnut-chocolate no-bake filling, finished with a Nutella drizzle.

PREP 20 MIN • CHILL 6 HOURS OR OVERNIGHT • 9-INCH SPRINGFORM PAN • 12 SLICES

CRUST

- 1 1/2 cups (150g) chocolate cookie crumbs
- 5 tbsp (70g) unsalted butter, melted

FILLING

- 24 oz (680g) cream cheese, softened
- 3/4 cup (200g) chocolate-hazelnut spread
- 1/2 cup (60g) powdered sugar
- 1 1/2 cups (360ml) heavy cream, cold
- 2 tbsp chocolate-hazelnut spread, warmed, for drizzling

METHOD

1. Press the crust into the pan and chill.
2. Beat the cream cheese, chocolate-hazelnut spread, and powdered sugar until smooth.
3. Whip the cold cream to stiff peaks, then fold into the mixture in two additions.
4. Spread over the crust, refrigerate at least 6 hours, then drizzle with warmed chocolate-hazelnut spread before serving.

Storage: Refrigerate up to 4 days.

Allergens: Contains wheat, dairy, hazelnuts.

No-Bake Blueberry Cheesecake

A no-bake filling topped with a cooked blueberry sauce rather than folding the fruit in.

PREP 20 MIN • CHILL 6 HOURS OR OVERNIGHT • 9-INCH SPRINGFORM PAN • 12 SLICES

CRUST

- 1 1/2 cups (150g) graham cracker crumbs
- 5 tbsp (70g) unsalted butter, melted

FILLING

- 24 oz (680g) cream cheese, softened
- 1 cup (120g) powdered sugar
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- 1 1/2 cups (360ml) heavy cream, cold

BLUEBERRY SAUCE

- 2 cups (300g) blueberries, fresh or frozen
- 1/4 cup granulated sugar
- 1 tsp cornstarch mixed with 1 tsp water
- 1 tsp lemon juice

METHOD

1. For the sauce, cook the blueberries, sugar, and lemon juice over medium heat until they release their juices, about 5 minutes, then stir in the cornstarch slurry and simmer until thickened. Cool completely.
2. Press the crust into the pan and chill.
3. Beat the cream cheese, powdered sugar, and vanilla until smooth.
4. Whip the cold cream to stiff peaks, then fold into the cream cheese mixture.
5. Spread over the crust, refrigerate at least 6 hours, then top with the cooled blueberry sauce just before serving.

Storage: Refrigerate up to 4 days.

Allergens: Contains wheat and dairy.

PART 4

Cupcakes

Sixteen cupcake recipes, spanning chocolate, vanilla, and fruit bases, plus filled and decorated variations.

Classic Vanilla Cupcakes

A reliable base for any frosting from the decorating handbook.

PREP 15 MIN • BAKE 18-20 MIN • 12-CUP MUFFIN TIN WITH LINERS • 350F/175C • 12 CUPCAKES

- 1 3/4 cups (220g) all-purpose flour
- 1 cup (200g) granulated sugar
- 1/2 cup (113g) unsalted butter, softened
- 2 large eggs
- 3/4 cup (180ml) whole milk
- 2 tsp baking powder
- 1/4 tsp salt
- 2 tsp vanilla extract

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 350F/175C. Line a muffin tin with paper liners.
2. Whisk the flour, baking powder, and salt together.
3. Beat the butter and sugar until fluffy, add the eggs one at a time, then the vanilla.
4. Alternate adding the flour mixture and milk, starting and ending with flour.
5. Divide among the liners, filling two-thirds full. Bake 18-20 minutes, until a toothpick comes out clean.
6. Cool completely before frosting.

Storage: Unfrosted, keeps covered for 2 days.

Allergens: Contains wheat, egg, and dairy.

Chocolate Fudge Cupcakes

A rich, fudgy cupcake using the hot-coffee trick for deeper chocolate flavor.

PREP 15 MIN • BAKE 18-20 MIN • 12-CUP MUFFIN TIN WITH LINERS • 350F/175C • 12 CUPCAKES

- 1 cup (125g) all-purpose flour
- 1 cup (200g) granulated sugar
- 1/3 cup (30g) unsweetened cocoa powder
- 1 tsp baking soda
- 1/2 tsp baking powder
- 1/2 tsp salt
- 1 large egg
- 1/2 cup (120ml) buttermilk
- 1/4 cup (60ml) vegetable oil
- 1/2 cup (120ml) hot coffee

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 350F/175C. Line a muffin tin with paper liners.
2. Whisk the flour, sugar, cocoa, baking soda, baking powder, and salt together.
3. Add the egg, buttermilk, and oil, whisk smooth, then stir in the hot coffee.
4. Divide among the liners, filling two-thirds full. Bake 18-20 minutes, until a toothpick comes out clean.
5. Cool completely before frosting.

Storage: Unfrosted, keeps covered for 2 days.

Allergens: Contains wheat, egg, and dairy.

Lemon Cupcakes

Bright with fresh lemon zest, pairs well with lemon buttercream or lemon curd filling.

PREP 15 MIN • BAKE 18-20 MIN • 12-CUP MUFFIN TIN WITH LINERS • 350F/175C • 12 CUPCAKES

- 1 3/4 cups (220g) all-purpose flour
- 1 cup (200g) granulated sugar
- 1/2 cup (113g) unsalted butter, softened
- 2 large eggs
- 1/2 cup (120ml) whole milk
- 2 tsp baking powder
- 1/4 tsp salt
- Zest of 2 lemons
- 2 tbsp fresh lemon juice

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 350F/175C. Line a muffin tin with paper liners.
2. Whisk the flour, baking powder, and salt together.
3. Beat the butter, sugar, and lemon zest until fluffy, add the eggs one at a time.
4. Alternate adding the flour mixture and milk mixed with lemon juice, starting and ending with flour.
5. Divide among the liners, filling two-thirds full. Bake 18-20 minutes, until a toothpick comes out clean.
6. Cool completely before frosting.

Storage: Unfrosted, keeps covered for 2 days.

Red Velvet Cupcakes

A cupcake-sized version of the classic layer cake, finished with cream cheese frosting.

PREP 15 MIN • BAKE 18-20 MIN • 12-CUP MUFFIN TIN WITH LINERS • 350F/175C • 12 CUPCAKES

- 1 1/4 cups (155g) all-purpose flour
- 3/4 cup (150g) granulated sugar
- 1/4 cup (55g) unsalted butter, softened
- 1/4 cup (60ml) vegetable oil
- 1 large egg
- 1/2 cup (120ml) buttermilk
- 1/2 tbsp unsweetened cocoa powder
- 1/2 tsp baking soda
- 1/4 tsp salt
- 1/2 tsp white vinegar
- 1/2 tsp vanilla extract
- 1 tsp red food coloring

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 350F/175C. Line a muffin tin with paper liners.
2. Whisk the flour, cocoa, baking soda, and salt together.
3. Beat the butter, oil, and sugar until fluffy, then add the egg.
4. Mix the buttermilk, vinegar, vanilla, and food coloring together, then alternate adding it with the flour mixture.
5. Divide among the liners, filling two-thirds full. Bake 18-20 minutes.
6. Cool completely before frosting, traditionally with cream cheese frosting.

Storage: Unfrosted, keeps covered for 2 days.

Carrot Cupcakes

A cupcake-sized carrot cake, good with cream cheese frosting.

PREP 20 MIN • BAKE 18-20 MIN • 12-CUP MUFFIN TIN WITH LINERS • 350F/175C • 12 CUPCAKES

- 1 1/4 cups (155g) all-purpose flour
- 3/4 cup (150g) granulated sugar
- 1/2 cup (120ml) vegetable oil
- 2 large eggs
- 1 1/2 cups finely grated carrots
- 1 tsp baking soda
- 1/2 tsp baking powder
- 1/2 tsp salt
- 1 tsp ground cinnamon

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 350F/175C. Line a muffin tin with paper liners.
2. Whisk the flour, baking soda, baking powder, salt, and cinnamon together.
3. Whisk the oil, sugar, and eggs together, then fold in the dry ingredients, then the grated carrots.
4. Divide among the liners, filling two-thirds full. Bake 18-20 minutes.
5. Cool completely before frosting.

Storage: Unfrosted, keeps covered for 2 days.

Filled Chocolate Cupcakes

Chocolate cupcakes with a whipped ganache or pastry cream center, piped in after baking.

PREP 20 MIN • BAKE 18-20 MIN • 12-CUP MUFFIN TIN WITH LINERS • 350F/175C • 12 CUPCAKES

CUPCAKES

- 1 cup (125g) all-purpose flour
- 1 cup (200g) granulated sugar
- 1/3 cup (30g) unsweetened cocoa powder
- 1 tsp baking soda
- 1/2 tsp baking powder
- 1/2 tsp salt
- 1 large egg
- 1/2 cup (120ml) buttermilk
- 1/4 cup (60ml) vegetable oil
- 1/2 cup (120ml) hot coffee

FILLING

- 1/2 batch Whipped Ganache Filling or Pastry Cream (see Decorating Handbook)

METHOD

1. Bake the chocolate cupcake batter as in the standard recipe and cool completely.
2. Using a small knife or a cupcake corer, remove a small cone from the center of each cupcake.
3. Pipe or spoon the filling into the cavity.
4. Trim the removed cone's top and replace it, or simply frost over the filled opening.

Storage: Keeps refrigerated for 3 days once filled.

Banana Cupcakes

A good use for very ripe bananas, pairs well with cream cheese or peanut butter frosting.

PREP 15 MIN • BAKE 18-20 MIN • 12-CUP MUFFIN TIN WITH LINERS • 350F/175C • 12 CUPCAKES

- 1 1/2 cups (190g) all-purpose flour
- 3/4 cup (150g) packed brown sugar
- 1/3 cup (75g) unsalted butter, softened
- 1 large egg
- 2 very ripe bananas, mashed
- 1/4 cup (60ml) whole milk
- 1 tsp baking powder
- 1/4 tsp baking soda
- 1/4 tsp salt

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 350F/175C. Line a muffin tin with paper liners.
2. Whisk the flour, baking powder, baking soda, and salt together.
3. Beat the butter and brown sugar until fluffy, add the egg, then the mashed banana.
4. Alternate adding the flour mixture and milk, starting and ending with flour.
5. Divide among the liners, filling two-thirds full. Bake 18-20 minutes.
6. Cool completely before frosting.

Storage: Unfrosted, keeps covered for 2 days.

Coconut Cupcakes

A vanilla base with coconut milk and shredded coconut, good topped with toasted coconut flakes.

PREP 15 MIN • BAKE 18-20 MIN • 12-CUP MUFFIN TIN WITH LINERS • 350F/175C • 12 CUPCAKES

- 1 3/4 cups (220g) all-purpose flour
- 1 cup (200g) granulated sugar
- 1/2 cup (113g) unsalted butter, softened
- 2 large eggs
- 3/4 cup (180ml) coconut milk
- 2 tsp baking powder
- 1/4 tsp salt
- 1/2 cup (40g) shredded coconut

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 350F/175C. Line a muffin tin with paper liners.
2. Whisk the flour, baking powder, and salt together.
3. Beat the butter and sugar until fluffy, add the eggs one at a time.
4. Alternate adding the flour mixture and coconut milk, then fold in the shredded coconut.
5. Divide among the liners, filling two-thirds full. Bake 18-20 minutes, until a toothpick comes out clean.
6. Cool completely before frosting; garnish with toasted coconut flakes if desired.

Storage: Unfrosted, keeps covered for 2 days.

Strawberry Cupcakes

Made with real strawberry puree, not extract or flavoring, for genuine fruit flavor.

PREP 20 MIN • BAKE 18-20 MIN • 12-CUP MUFFIN TIN WITH LINERS • 350F/175C • 12 CUPCAKES

- 1 3/4 cups (220g) all-purpose flour
- 3/4 cup (150g) granulated sugar
- 1/2 cup (113g) unsalted butter, softened
- 2 large eggs
- 1/2 cup (120g) strawberry puree (about 1 cup fresh strawberries, blended and strained)
- 2 tsp baking powder
- 1/4 tsp salt

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 350F/175C. Line a muffin tin with paper liners.
2. Whisk the flour, baking powder, and salt together.
3. Beat the butter and sugar until fluffy, add the eggs one at a time, then the strawberry puree (the batter may look slightly curdled — this is normal).
4. Fold in the flour mixture just until combined.
5. Divide among the liners, filling two-thirds full. Bake 18-20 minutes, until a toothpick comes out clean.
6. Cool completely before frosting.

Storage: Unfrosted, keeps covered for 2 days.

Salted Caramel Filled Cupcakes

A vanilla cupcake cored and filled with salted caramel sauce before frosting.

PREP 20 MIN • BAKE 18-20 MIN • 12-CUP MUFFIN TIN WITH LINERS • 350F/175C • 12 CUPCAKES

CUPCAKES

- 1 3/4 cups (220g) all-purpose flour
- 1 cup (200g) granulated sugar
- 1/2 cup (113g) unsalted butter, softened
- 2 large eggs
- 3/4 cup (180ml) whole milk
- 2 tsp baking powder
- 1/4 tsp salt

FILLING

- 1/2 cup prepared salted caramel sauce (see Cheesecake chapter or store-bought)

METHOD

1. Bake the vanilla cupcake batter as in the standard recipe and cool completely.
2. Using a small knife or cupcake corer, remove a small cone from the center of each cupcake.
3. Fill each cavity with about 1 tsp salted caramel sauce.
4. Trim the removed cone's top and replace it, or frost directly over the filled opening.

Storage: Keeps covered for 2 days; refrigerate if filled more than a few hours ahead.

Peanut Butter Cupcakes

Peanut butter folded into the batter itself, not just the frosting.

PREP 15 MIN • BAKE 18-20 MIN • 12-CUP MUFFIN TIN WITH LINERS • 350F/175C • 12 CUPCAKES

- 1 3/4 cups (220g) all-purpose flour
- 3/4 cup (150g) granulated sugar
- 1/2 cup (130g) creamy peanut butter
- 1/4 cup (55g) unsalted butter, softened
- 2 large eggs
- 3/4 cup (180ml) whole milk
- 2 tsp baking powder
- 1/4 tsp salt

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 350F/175C. Line a muffin tin with paper liners.
2. Whisk the flour, baking powder, and salt together.
3. Beat the peanut butter, butter, and sugar until fluffy, add the eggs one at a time.
4. Alternate adding the flour mixture and milk, starting and ending with flour.
5. Divide among the liners, filling two-thirds full. Bake 18-20 minutes, until a toothpick comes out clean.
6. Cool completely before frosting.

Storage: Unfrosted, keeps covered for 2 days.

Allergens: Contains wheat, egg, dairy, and peanuts.

Funfetti Cupcakes

A vanilla base studded with rainbow sprinkles, a favorite for birthdays and kids' parties.

PREP 15 MIN • BAKE 18-20 MIN • 12-CUP MUFFIN TIN WITH LINERS • 350F/175C • 12 CUPCAKES

- 1 3/4 cups (220g) all-purpose flour
- 1 cup (200g) granulated sugar
- 1/2 cup (113g) unsalted butter, softened
- 2 large eggs
- 3/4 cup (180ml) whole milk
- 2 tsp baking powder
- 1/4 tsp salt
- 2 tsp vanilla extract
- 1/3 cup (60g) rainbow jimmies sprinkles

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 350F/175C. Line a muffin tin with paper liners.
2. Whisk the flour, baking powder, and salt together.
3. Beat the butter and sugar until fluffy, add the eggs one at a time, then the vanilla.
4. Alternate adding the flour mixture and milk, then gently fold in the sprinkles (use rod-shaped jimmies, not round nonpareils, which bleed color into the batter).
5. Divide among the liners, filling two-thirds full. Bake 18-20 minutes, until a toothpick comes out clean.
6. Cool completely before frosting; top with more sprinkles while the frosting is still wet.

Storage: Unfrosted, keeps covered for 2 days.

Cookies and Cream Cupcakes

Crushed sandwich cookies folded into a vanilla batter, with a whole cookie baked into the bottom of each liner.

PREP 15 MIN • BAKE 18-20 MIN • 12-CUP MUFFIN TIN WITH LINERS • 350F/175C • 12 CUPCAKES

- 1 3/4 cups (220g) all-purpose flour
- 3/4 cup (150g) granulated sugar
- 1/2 cup (113g) unsalted butter, softened
- 2 large eggs
- 3/4 cup (180ml) whole milk
- 2 tsp baking powder
- 1/4 tsp salt
- 12 chocolate sandwich cookies (whole), plus 8 more, crushed

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 350F/175C. Line a muffin tin with paper liners and place one whole cookie flat in the bottom of each.
2. Whisk the flour, baking powder, and salt together.
3. Beat the butter and sugar until fluffy, add the eggs one at a time.
4. Alternate adding the flour mixture and milk, then fold in the crushed cookies.
5. Divide the batter among the liners, over the whole cookies. Bake 18-20 minutes, until a toothpick comes out clean.
6. Cool completely before frosting.

Storage: Unfrosted, keeps covered for 2 days.

Pumpkin Spice Cupcakes

Built on real pumpkin puree and warm spices, good with cream cheese frosting.

PREP 15 MIN • BAKE 18-20 MIN • 12-CUP MUFFIN TIN WITH LINERS • 350F/175C • 12 CUPCAKES

- 1 1/2 cups (190g) all-purpose flour
- 3/4 cup (150g) packed brown sugar
- 1/3 cup (75g) unsalted butter, softened
- 1 cup (240g) pumpkin puree
- 2 large eggs
- 1 1/2 tsp baking powder
- 1/4 tsp baking soda
- 1 1/2 tsp ground cinnamon
- 1/2 tsp ground ginger
- 1/4 tsp ground cloves

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 350F/175C. Line a muffin tin with paper liners.
2. Whisk the flour, baking powder, baking soda, and spices together.
3. Beat the butter and brown sugar until fluffy, add the eggs one at a time, then the pumpkin puree.
4. Fold in the flour mixture just until combined.
5. Divide among the liners, filling two-thirds full. Bake 18-20 minutes, until a toothpick comes out clean.
6. Cool completely before frosting.

Storage: Unfrosted, keeps covered for 2 days.

Pina Colada Cupcakes

A tropical pairing of crushed pineapple and coconut milk in the batter.

PREP 20 MIN • BAKE 18-20 MIN • 12-CUP MUFFIN TIN WITH LINERS • 350F/175C • 12 CUPCAKES

- 1 3/4 cups (220g) all-purpose flour
- 3/4 cup (150g) granulated sugar
- 1/2 cup (113g) unsalted butter, softened
- 2 large eggs
- 1/2 cup (120ml) coconut milk
- 1/3 cup (85g) crushed pineapple, well drained
- 2 tsp baking powder
- 1/4 tsp salt

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 350F/175C. Line a muffin tin with paper liners.
2. Whisk the flour, baking powder, and salt together.
3. Beat the butter and sugar until fluffy, add the eggs one at a time.
4. Alternate adding the flour mixture and coconut milk, then fold in the well-drained crushed pineapple.
5. Divide among the liners, filling two-thirds full. Bake 18-20 minutes, until a toothpick comes out clean.
6. Cool completely before frosting.

Storage: Unfrosted, keeps covered for 2 days.

Black Forest Cupcakes

Chocolate cupcakes cored and filled with cherry filling, topped with whipped cream frosting.

PREP 20 MIN • BAKE 18-20 MIN • 12-CUP MUFFIN TIN WITH LINERS • 350F/175C • 12 CUPCAKES

CUPCAKES

- 1 cup (125g) all-purpose flour
- 1 cup (200g) granulated sugar
- 1/3 cup (30g) unsweetened cocoa powder
- 1 tsp baking soda
- 1/2 tsp baking powder
- 1/2 tsp salt
- 1 large egg
- 1/2 cup (120ml) buttermilk
- 1/4 cup (60ml) vegetable oil
- 1/2 cup (120ml) hot coffee

FILLING

- 1/2 cup prepared cherry filling (see Cheesecake chapter's cherry swirl method or canned cherry pie filling)

METHOD

1. Bake the chocolate cupcake batter as in the standard recipe and cool completely.
2. Core each cupcake and fill with about 1 tsp cherry filling.
3. Replace the trimmed cone top or frost directly over the opening with whipped cream frosting.
4. Garnish with a whole cherry if desired.

Storage: Keeps refrigerated for 2 days once filled.

PART 5

Mini Cakes & Individual Desserts

Twelve small-format desserts, including mini layer cakes, individual baked and no-bake treats, and portable jarred desserts.

Mini Vanilla Layer Cakes (4-Inch)

Individual-sized layer cakes, good for small gatherings or practicing decorating at a smaller scale.

PREP 20 MIN • BAKE 20-22 MIN • TWO 4-INCH ROUND PANS (OR ONE PAN, BAKED TWICE) • 350F/175C • 2 SMALL 2-LAYER CAKES

- 1 1/2 cups (190g) all-purpose flour
- 1 cup (200g) granulated sugar
- 1/2 cup (113g) unsalted butter, softened
- 2 large eggs
- 1/2 cup (120ml) whole milk
- 2 tsp baking powder
- 1/4 tsp salt
- 1 tsp vanilla extract

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 350F/175C. Grease four 4-inch pans (or bake in two batches).
2. Whisk the flour, baking powder, and salt together.
3. Beat the butter and sugar until fluffy, add the eggs one at a time, then the vanilla.
4. Alternate adding the flour mixture and milk.
5. Divide among the pans and bake 20-22 minutes, until a toothpick comes out clean.
6. Cool completely before stacking and frosting.

Storage: Unfrosted, keeps wrapped for 2 days.

Mini Chocolate Layer Cakes (4-Inch)

A small-format version of the classic chocolate layer cake.

PREP 20 MIN • BAKE 20-22 MIN • TWO 4-INCH ROUND PANS (OR ONE PAN, BAKED TWICE) • 350F/175C • 2 SMALL 2-LAYER CAKES

- 1 cup (125g) all-purpose flour
- 1 cup (200g) granulated sugar
- 1/3 cup (30g) unsweetened cocoa powder
- 1 tsp baking soda
- 1/2 tsp baking powder
- 1/2 tsp salt
- 1 large egg
- 1/2 cup (120ml) buttermilk
- 1/4 cup (60ml) vegetable oil
- 1/2 cup (120ml) hot coffee

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 350F/175C. Grease four 4-inch pans.
2. Whisk the flour, sugar, cocoa, baking soda, baking powder, and salt together.
3. Add the egg, buttermilk, and oil, whisk smooth, then stir in the hot coffee.
4. Divide among the pans and bake 20-22 minutes, until a toothpick comes out clean.
5. Cool completely before stacking and frosting.

Storage: Unfrosted, keeps wrapped for 2 days.

Individual Trifle Cups

Layers of cake, filling, and fruit in a glass — no frosting or decorating skill needed at all.

PREP 25 MIN • CHILL 2 HOURS • 6 SMALL GLASSES OR JARS • 6 INDIVIDUAL SERVINGS

- 3 cups cubed leftover cake (any flavor in this book)
- 1 batch Pastry Cream or Whipped Cream Frosting
- 2 cups mixed fresh berries
- 2 tbsp fruit jam, warmed and thinned with 1 tsp water (optional)

METHOD

1. In each glass, layer a small amount of cake cubes, then a spoonful of filling, then a few berries.
2. Repeat the layers until the glass is nearly full, finishing with a visible top layer of filling and berries.
3. Drizzle with thinned jam if using.
4. Chill at least 2 hours before serving to let the layers settle.

Storage: Refrigerate; best within 2 days.

Mini Ice Cream Cake Bites

A frozen, layered dessert using cake crumbs and softened ice cream — no oven needed after the cake is made.

PREP 25 MIN • CHILL 4 HOURS OR OVERNIGHT • 12-CUP MUFFIN TIN • 12 BITE-SIZED CAKES

- 2 cups cake crumbs (any leftover cake in this book)
- 3 tbsp unsalted butter, melted
- 2 cups softened ice cream, any flavor
- 1/2 cup magic shell chocolate topping or melted chocolate, for coating

METHOD

1. Line a muffin tin with cupcake liners.
2. Mix the cake crumbs with melted butter and press a thin layer into the bottom of each liner.
3. Fill each liner most of the way with softened ice cream and smooth the tops.
4. Freeze until firm, at least 4 hours or overnight.
5. Just before serving, drizzle or dip the tops in chocolate topping, which will harden quickly against the cold.

Storage: Keep frozen; best within 1 week.

Allergens: Contains wheat and dairy.

Mini Red Velvet Layer Cakes (4-Inch)

A small-format version of the classic red velvet, finished with cream cheese frosting.

PREP 20 MIN • BAKE 20-22 MIN • TWO 4-INCH ROUND PANS (OR ONE PAN, BAKED TWICE) • 350F/175C • 2 SMALL 2-LAYER CAKES

- 1 1/4 cups (155g) all-purpose flour
- 3/4 cup (150g) granulated sugar
- 1/4 cup (55g) unsalted butter, softened
- 1/4 cup (60ml) vegetable oil
- 1 large egg
- 1/2 cup (120ml) buttermilk
- 1/2 tbsp unsweetened cocoa powder
- 1/2 tsp baking soda
- 1/4 tsp salt
- 1/2 tsp white vinegar
- 1 tsp red food coloring

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 350F/175C. Grease four 4-inch pans.
2. Whisk the flour, cocoa, baking soda, and salt together.
3. Beat the butter, oil, and sugar until fluffy, then add the egg.
4. Mix the buttermilk, vinegar, and food coloring, then alternate adding it with the flour mixture.
5. Divide among the pans and bake 20-22 minutes, until a toothpick comes out clean.
6. Cool completely before stacking and frosting, traditionally with cream cheese frosting.

Storage: Unfrosted, keeps wrapped for 2 days.

Mini Lemon Layer Cakes (4-Inch)

A bright small-format cake, good filled with lemon curd between layers.

PREP 20 MIN • BAKE 20-22 MIN • TWO 4-INCH ROUND PANS (OR ONE PAN, BAKED TWICE) • 350F/175C • 2 SMALL 2-LAYER CAKES

- 1 1/2 cups (190g) all-purpose flour
- 1 cup (200g) granulated sugar
- 1/2 cup (113g) unsalted butter, softened
- 2 large eggs
- 1/2 cup (120ml) whole milk
- 2 tsp baking powder
- 1/4 tsp salt
- Zest of 1 lemon
- 1 tbsp fresh lemon juice

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 350F/175C. Grease four 4-inch pans.
2. Whisk the flour, baking powder, and salt together.
3. Beat the butter, sugar, and lemon zest until fluffy, add the eggs one at a time.
4. Alternate adding the flour mixture and milk mixed with lemon juice.
5. Divide among the pans and bake 20-22 minutes, until a toothpick comes out clean.
6. Cool completely before stacking with lemon curd and frosting.

Storage: Unfrosted, keeps wrapped for 2 days.

Individual Chocolate Lava Cakes

A warm, dense chocolate cake with a molten center, served straight from the ramekin.

PREP 15 MIN • BAKE 12-14 MIN • 4 RAMEKINS (6 OZ EACH) • 425F/220C • 4 INDIVIDUAL CAKES

- 4 oz (115g) semisweet chocolate, chopped
- 1/2 cup (113g) unsalted butter
- 1 cup (120g) powdered sugar
- 2 large eggs plus 2 egg yolks
- 1/4 cup (30g) all-purpose flour
- pinch of salt

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 425F/220C. Butter and lightly flour 4 ramekins.
2. Melt the chocolate and butter together, either in a double boiler or in short microwave bursts, stirring until smooth.
3. Whisk in the powdered sugar, then the eggs and egg yolks, then the flour and salt.
4. Divide among the ramekins and bake 12-14 minutes, until the sides are set but the center still looks soft.
5. Let rest 1 minute, then run a knife around the edge and invert onto plates. Serve immediately while the center is still molten.

Storage: Best baked and served fresh; batter can be refrigerated up to 1 day ahead, covered.

Allergens: Contains wheat and egg.

Mini Pavlovas with Cream and Berries

Crisp-shelled, marshmallow-centered meringue nests, topped just before serving so they stay crisp.

PREP 20 MIN • BAKE 60 MIN, PLUS COOLING IN THE OVEN • CHILL NONE • BAKING SHEET • 250F/120C • 8 MINI PAVLOVAS

MERINGUE

- 4 large egg whites, room temperature
- 1 cup (200g) granulated sugar
- 1 tsp cornstarch
- 1 tsp white vinegar

TOPPING

- 1 cup (240ml) heavy cream, whipped to soft peaks
- 2 cups mixed fresh berries

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 250F/120C. Line a baking sheet with parchment and draw eight 3-inch circles as a guide.
2. Whip the egg whites to soft peaks, then gradually add the sugar, whipping to stiff, glossy peaks. Fold in the cornstarch and vinegar.
3. Spoon or pipe the meringue into the circles, building up the edges slightly to form a shallow well.
4. Bake 60 minutes, then turn off the oven and let the meringues cool inside with the door closed for at least 1 hour, or until fully cool, to prevent cracking.
5. Just before serving, top each with whipped cream and berries — topping too far ahead will soften the crisp shell.

Storage: Store unfilled shells in an airtight container up to 3 days; fill only just before serving.

Allergens: Contains egg and dairy.

Cake Pops

A way to use leftover cake trimmings, bound with frosting and dipped in melted chocolate.

PREP 30 MIN • CHILL 1 HOUR • BAKING SHEET, LOLLIPOP STICKS • ABOUT 20 CAKE POPS

- 3 cups crumbled leftover cake (any flavor in this book)
- 1/3 cup prepared frosting (any flavor in the Decorating Handbook, or store-bought)
- 12 oz (340g) candy melts or chocolate, melted
- 20 lollipop sticks

METHOD

1. Crumble the cake finely into a bowl and mix with the frosting until it holds together when pressed.
2. Roll into 20 balls, about 1 1/2 tbsp each, and place on a parchment-lined sheet. Chill 1 hour, until firm.
3. Dip the tip of each stick into melted candy melts, then insert about halfway into a cake ball.
4. Dip each pop fully into the melted coating, letting excess drip off, then stand upright in a block of foam or a cup to set.

Storage: Keeps at room temperature in an airtight container up to 1 week.

Allergens: Varies by cake and coating used; typically contains wheat, egg, and dairy.

Individual Banana Pudding Cups

A layered no-bake dessert of pudding, bananas, and cookies, built in individual portions.

PREP 20 MIN • CHILL 2 HOURS • 6 SMALL CUPS • 6 INDIVIDUAL SERVINGS

- 2 cups prepared vanilla pudding (homemade or store-bought)
- 1 cup (240ml) heavy cream, whipped to soft peaks
- 3 bananas, sliced
- 24 vanilla wafer cookies

METHOD

1. Fold half the whipped cream into the pudding to lighten it.
2. In each cup, layer a few cookies, a few banana slices, and a spoonful of the pudding mixture.
3. Repeat the layers, finishing with a dollop of the remaining whipped cream and a cookie crumb garnish.
4. Chill at least 2 hours before serving so the cookies soften slightly.

Storage: Refrigerate; best within 1 day, as the bananas will darken over time.

Allergens: Contains wheat, egg, and dairy.

Mini Carrot Cake Jars

Baked carrot cake crumbled and layered with cream cheese frosting in individual jars.

PREP 25 MIN • BAKE 18-20 MIN • CHILL 1 HOUR • 12-CUP MUFFIN TIN, 6 SMALL JARS • 350F/175C • 6 INDIVIDUAL JARS

- 1 batch Carrot Cupcakes batter (see Cupcakes chapter)
- 1 batch Cream Cheese Frosting (see Decorating Handbook)
- 1/4 cup chopped walnuts, toasted (optional)

METHOD

1. Bake the carrot cupcake batter in a muffin tin as directed and cool completely.
2. Crumble the baked cupcakes into coarse pieces.
3. In each jar, layer crumbled cake, a spoonful of frosting, more cake, and a final layer of frosting on top.
4. Top with chopped toasted walnuts if using. Chill at least 1 hour before serving so the layers set slightly.

Storage: Refrigerate up to 3 days.

Allergens: Contains wheat, egg, and dairy; walnuts if used.

Individual Tiramisu Cups

A no-bake, egg-free version of tiramisu built in individual cups, layered with coffee-soaked ladyfingers.

PREP 25 MIN • CHILL 4 HOURS OR OVERNIGHT • 6 SMALL GLASSES OR JARS • 6 INDIVIDUAL SERVINGS

- 16 ladyfinger cookies
- 1 cup (240ml) strong brewed coffee, cooled
- 8 oz (225g) mascarpone, softened
- 1 cup (240ml) heavy cream, cold
- 1/3 cup (40g) powdered sugar
- 2 tbsp cocoa powder, for dusting

METHOD

1. Whip the cold cream and powdered sugar to stiff peaks, then gently fold in the mascarpone until smooth.
2. Quickly dip each ladyfinger in the cooled coffee, just long enough to moisten without turning soggy.
3. In each cup, layer dipped ladyfingers (broken to fit), then a layer of the mascarpone cream.
4. Repeat the layers, finishing with cream on top.
5. Chill at least 4 hours or overnight, then dust with cocoa powder just before serving.

Storage: Refrigerate up to 3 days.

Allergens: Contains wheat and dairy.

Recipe Index

Classic New York Cheesecake

Baked Vanilla Bean Cheesecake

Baked Chocolate Cheesecake

Baked Lemon Cheesecake

Baked Pumpkin Cheesecake

Baked Cherry Swirl Cheesecake

- Mini Baked Cheesecakes
- Baked Salted Caramel Cheesecake
- Baked Oreo Cheesecake
- Baked Raspberry Swirl Cheesecake
- Baked Tiramisu Cheesecake
- Baked Apple Cinnamon Cheesecake
- No-Bake Classic Cheesecake
- No-Bake Strawberry Cheesecake
- No-Bake Chocolate Cheesecake
- No-Bake Key Lime Cheesecake
- No-Bake Peanut Butter Cheesecake
- No-Bake Mini Cheesecake Cups
- No-Bake Oreo Cheesecake
- No-Bake Mango Cheesecake
- No-Bake Nutella Cheesecake
- No-Bake Blueberry Cheesecake
- Classic Vanilla Cupcakes
- Chocolate Fudge Cupcakes
- Lemon Cupcakes
- Red Velvet Cupcakes
- Carrot Cupcakes
- Filled Chocolate Cupcakes
- Banana Cupcakes
- Coconut Cupcakes
- Strawberry Cupcakes
- Salted Caramel Filled Cupcakes
- Peanut Butter Cupcakes
- Funfetti Cupcakes
- Cookies and Cream Cupcakes
- Pumpkin Spice Cupcakes
- Pina Colada Cupcakes
- Black Forest Cupcakes
- Mini Vanilla Layer Cakes (4-Inch)
- Mini Chocolate Layer Cakes (4-Inch)
- Individual Trifle Cups
- Mini Ice Cream Cake Bites
- Mini Red Velvet Layer Cakes (4-Inch)
- Mini Lemon Layer Cakes (4-Inch)
- Individual Chocolate Lava Cakes
- Mini Pavlovas with Cream and Berries
- Cake Pops
- Individual Banana Pudding Cups
- Mini Carrot Cake Jars
- Individual Tiramisu Cups